10 SWAPS, AND WHAT TO SAY WHEN THE DATE MOVES

What to Say When You Need a Date From Your Engineers

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1 When you need an estimate, ask for a range

Ask for the best case and the worst case, then ask what decides where it lands.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Don't say:** "Ballpark, how long will this take?"
> **Instead say:** "What's the best case and the worst case?"
>
> **Don't say:** "Can you get me a number by end of day?"
> **Instead say:** "Give me a range today and a firmer date after the spike."

Put both ends in the plan. When you share it upward, share the range.

2 When the date is fixed, make the scope the question

Keep the date and ask what comes out. Pushing harder just means somebody works Saturday.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Don't say:** "We really need this by the 15th."
> **Instead say:** "To hit the 15th, what would you cut first?"
>
> **Don't say:** "Can the team push a little harder this sprint?"
> **Instead say:** "If the date holds, what's the smallest version that ships?"

If the date can't move, go in ready to cut something.

3 When something looks small, ask what's behind it

Let the engineer size it. Your job is to ask what it touches.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Don't say:** "This should be a quick one, right?"
> **Instead say:** "What's behind this that I can't see from here?"
>
> **Don't say:** "It's only a config change."
> **Instead say:** "What else reads that config?"

If you call it small first, that's the number they'll try to hit.

4 When leadership sets the date, bring the reason with it

Pass down why the date matters. When they know what it's for, they can tell you what's safe to cut.

> EXAMPLE
> **Don't say:** "The VP wants this by Friday."
> **Instead say:** "The VP needs this Friday for the quarterly review. Is Friday real?"
> **Don't say:** "This is top priority from leadership."
> **Instead say:** "Sales needs this for a renewal, so it moved up. What drops to make room?"

If you don't know why the date matters, find out before you bring it to the team.

5 When it's late, ask what changed

Ask what the team found that the estimate didn't include.

> EXAMPLE
> **Don't say:** "Why is this still not done?"
> **Instead say:** "What did we find since the estimate?"
> **Don't say:** "You said two weeks."
> **Instead say:** "We planned two weeks. What showed up that we didn't see?"

Write down what the estimate missed and bring it to the next planning meeting.

6 When the date moves, you're the one who says it

Tell the people waiting yourself. Give the new date, what caused it, what's already done, and when you'll confirm.

> EXAMPLE
> **Don't say:** "Engineering is behind again."
> **Instead say:** "We're moving to the 21st. The payment API needed a migration we didn't see in planning. Checkout is done, and I'll confirm the 21st on Monday."

Say it as your date, not engineering's.

Check every date ask before you send it

Run this before you ask your team for a date:

- [ ] Did you ask for a range instead of one number?
- [ ] If the date is fixed, did you say what can come out?
- [ ] Did you pass down why the date matters?
- [ ] If it's late, did you ask what changed before asking why?
- [ ] If the date moves, are you the one telling people?